A SHIPPER'S RESOURCE

Customs Clearance Readiness Checklist

12 things to confirm before you book your next shipment, so nothing slips at the border.

Why Late Customs Fixes Cost You

Clearance delays rarely start at the port. They usually trace back to documents, classifications or values that were never reconciled before the cargo arrived, so the fix happens late, under storage charges and a waiting consignee. Mills Customs works with importers to catch these gaps early, alongside Mills Permits and Mills Logistics for everything around the entry.

Work through each point before you book. If you cannot tick a box, that is the item to resolve first.

The Readiness Checklist

- [ ] **1. Importer and exporter registration is current**
  Confirm your company's customs registration and any related accreditation are active, and that the name on them matches the consignee on every shipping document.

- [ ] **2. Permits and approvals are mapped**
  Check whether any agency permit, license or clearance applies to your product, and that it covers this shipment before the goods leave origin.

- [ ] **3. The tariff classification is settled**
  Agree on the HS code for each product line, and make sure the same code and description appear on the invoice, packing list and any permits.

- [ ] **4. The customs value can be supported**
  Have the commercial invoice, payment terms, freight and insurance records ready so the declared value is easy to explain if it is questioned.

- [ ] **5. Duties and taxes are estimated and funded**
  Prepare an estimate of duties and taxes for the entry, and confirm who pays and when, so release is not held up waiting on funds.

- [ ] **6. Rules of origin and preferential rates are checked**
  If you plan to claim a preferential tariff, confirm the origin documents required and that they will be in hand in time for the entry.

- [ ] **7. Special regimes are confirmed**
  For PEZA or free-zone cargo, temporary importation or re-exportation, confirm the correct treatment and the authorizing documents before shipping.

- [ ] **8. The document set is reconciled**
  Compare the invoice, packing list and bill of lading or air waybill line by line for names, quantities, descriptions and values, and fix mismatches now.

- [ ] **9. Documents reach your broker before arrival**
  Send the complete set to your broker ahead of the arrival date so the entry can be prepared and reviewed instead of rushed.

The Readiness Checklist (continued)

- [ ] **10. You are ready for an examination or hold**
  Name a contact who can answer questions quickly, and keep supporting documents on hand in case the cargo is selected for examination or held.

- [ ] **11. Release and onward delivery are planned**
  Line up payment, release, trucking and any storage before arrival, so cleared cargo moves straight on instead of sitting at the port.

- [ ] **12. Records and remedies are in place**
  Keep entry documents organized after release, and know how a disputed assessment or a correction would be raised and by whom.

Not sure every box is ticked? Let Mills Customs review it with you.

Book a short call and we will walk through your next shipment and flag anything to resolve before it moves.

BOOK A CALL

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General guidance only, not legal advice. Requirements vary by product and shipment; confirm with The Mills before booking.